LETICIA PIERAERTS

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Belgian and Spanish. Born April 9, 1997.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Theoretical and Empirical Industrial Organization, Environmental and Energy Economics, Electricity markets

POSITION

Université libre de Bruxelles, Belgium *Oct 2021 – now*
PhD Candidate in Economics
Supervisor: Estelle Cantillon
Grant from the Federal Energy Transition Fund (Project Demandflex)

EDUCATION

Toulouse School of Economics *Jan 2026 – April 2026*
Visiting PhD Candidate in Environmental research group
Host: Stefan Ambec

Université libre de Bruxelles, Belgium *Sept 2021 – Sept 2023*
MRes Research in Economics
Magna cum Laude

Université libre de Bruxelles, Belgium *Sept 2019 – Aug 2021*
MSc Economics
Exchange semester at the Technical University of Munich (Germany)
Quantitative Techniques for Economics and Management (QTEM) network
Magna cum Laude

Université libre de Bruxelles, Belgium *Sept 2015 – Aug 2018*
BSc Economics
Magna cum Laude

RESEARCH PROJECTS

Who benefits from the energy transition? Market power and flexibility in retail electricity markets
with Elise Viadere **[Job Market Paper]**

Abstract: The energy transition widens intraday spot price spreads—the difference between the most and least expensive hours of the day—raising the value of consumers' flexibility. We study a monopolist retailer offering contracts to consumers with heterogeneous, privately known intraday flexibility. In equilibrium, the retailer screens consumers through the contracts' price spread, and extracts surplus through the price level. Only the most flexible face the full spot price spread and consume efficiently; less flexible consumers face compressed price spreads. This distortion increases with the share of flexible consumers. The retailer captures most flexibility gains; low-flexibility consumers retain none.

Vertical arrangements and market power with real-time pricing: Evidence from the Spanish electricity market

Abstract: In electricity markets, vertical integration between production and retail commitments has been shown to be pro-competitive: it reduces producers' net position on the spot market, lowering their incentive to exercise market power (Bushnell et al., 2008). This result holds under fixed-price contracts, where consumers face a fixed price for the entire delivery period. With real-time pricing, retailers no longer need to commit to a retail price before participating on the spot market. How does this affect price formation on the retail and spot market? I develop a model of strategic behavior of vertically integrated firms with real-time pricing and find that the pro-competitive effect of vertical integration disappears entirely. I test the model predictions using microdata from the Spanish electricity market where real-time pricing was introduced as the default retail contract in 2015. I find evidence that the observed changes in spot prices and firm behavior are consistent with the model.

Electricity market architecture, contracts and real-time price exposure of large industrial consumers *with Estelle Cantillon*

Abstract: Despite accounting for a significant share of total electricity consumption, industrial consumers exhibit limited demand-response. This paper looks at the role of contractual arrangements in mediating industrial demand-response. Leveraging a unique dataset of retail contracts for large industrial consumers in Belgium over 2014-2024, we document that contractual arrangements between large industrial consumers and their retailer have undergone a major transformation over the past decade and that, today, those consumers are much more exposed to real-time price signals. We plan to build a theoretical model to link contract choice with consumer characteristics. Next, we plan to quantify the extent to which the increased financial incentives for providing flexibility materialize into higher effective demand-side flexibility by industrial consumers.

PUBLICATIONS

Cantillon, E., & Pieraerts, L. (2023). La transition énergétique en Belgique : États des lieux. In E. Cantillon, S. Brunet, J. Eyckmans, A. Gautier, M. Muûls, & F. Venmans (Eds.), Réussir la transition vers une économie zéro carbone. Editions de l'Université Ouverte.

POLICY WORK

Study on cost pass-through in energy retail markets 2018 – 24 (Belgium, France, Germany, Spain), for the European Commission – DG ENER (with Estelle Cantillon, Stefan Lamp, Mar Reguant, Isabelle Méjean, Mattia Nardotto and Elise Viadere)

SEMINARS, CONFERENCES AND SUMMER SCHOOLS

2026: TSE Environmental Workshop (Toulouse), Energy Workshop (Madrid), EDF R&D Seminar (Paris Saclay), ENTER Conference (Madrid), EDF x TSE Workshop (Paris)

2025: Young Energy Economists and Engineers Seminar 2025 (Paris), Climate Policy Summer School (Berlin), FAEE PhD conference (Grenoble), CREG internal seminar (Brussels), ECARES PhD Day (Brussels), AEE annual conference [poster] (Paris)

2024: ECARES internal seminar, ECARES PhD seminar (Brussels)

2023: SRBE Study Day on Flexible Loads (Brussels), ETF Project Conference (Ghent), ECARES PhD seminar (Brussels)

2022: Energy Workshop (TSE), Summer School on Empirical Methods for the Analysis of the Energy Transition (BSE, Barcelona)

TEACHING AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

TA Advanced Industrial Organization, Faculty of Economics (2023)
For Mattia Nardotto

TA Energy Policy and Management, Ecole Polytechnique de Bruxelles (2023, 2024, 2025)
For Benjamin Genêt

Research Assistant, ECARES (June-Oct 2021)
For Estelle Cantillon

- Data cleaning and processing on the EU Emissions Trading Scheme

WORK EXPERIENCE

National Organization for Hydrogen and Fuel Cell Battery (NOW GmbH), Berlin (Germany) *Sept 2018 – Aug 2019*
Internship in Communication and Knowledge Management

TECHNICAL AND LANGUAGE SKILLS

Programming/statistical software: Python, R, STATA, LaTeX
Collaboration software: Git, Github, Overleaf
Languages: French (native), Spanish (native), English (C2), German (B2+)